

some online banks). And credit unions typically charge less for everything from money orders to bounced checks. As with your deposits in a traditional bank, the money you have in a credit union (up to \$250,000 until at least December 2009) is federally insured.

But before you sign up with a credit union, see if it offers all the services you want. Although more and more credit unions belong to ATM networks that are controlled by fellow credit unions, they still operate a relatively small number of machines compared to what banks offer. That means credit union members must often use a bank's ATM and pay high fees for the privilege. Also, not all credit unions offer online access to accounts.

Still, if you like the idea of doing your banking with a nonprofit community outlet, look into a credit union to see if it's right for you. If you work for your city, chances are there's a credit union available to you. Contact the Credit Union National Association ([www.cuna.org](http://www.cuna.org); 800-358-5710) to find a website or phone number for your state's credit union league. The league will help you locate a credit union that you may be able to join. For example, your church, synagogue, or alma mater may have one, or your community may have a credit union whose members are people who live in the neighborhood. If you have a relative who belongs to a credit union, you might be eligible to enroll; some credit unions accept immediate family members only, while others allow members of the extended family to sign up.

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## ↓ **USING THE ATM WISELY**

Not that long ago, banks didn't charge you for using ATMs at all. They wanted to encourage customers to bank by machine so they could save money on tellers' salaries. It worked. And then, when everyone started getting hooked, banks started charging consumers to use them. Today, people spend billions of dollars a year on ATM fees; I know plenty of people who throw away hundreds of dollars a year on their cash machine addictions. Here's how I suggest you keep those ATM habits—and your spending—in check: